fresh, discreet channel of communication with Pakistan. It is now clear that one of the reasons for the relative peace on the LoC between 2016 and 2020 had been the contacts between the National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and the then Pakistan army chief Qamar Bajwa and his ISI chief, Faiz Hameed.

While this channel of communication may have been interrupted, if not disrupted, it may be worthwhile to establish it once again. With Nawaz Sharif emerging as the strongest political actor in Pakistan, and with his natural penchant to be a deal-maker, and with the army being snowed under by the restive situation within the country, it may be useful to pursue a careful, incremental agenda. This will ensure that Pakistan recognises the follies of its past actions and is, hopefully, willing to accept and live with the status quo.

IT IS CRITICAL THAT ELECTIONS ARE COMPLETELY FREE AND FAIR. IN THE PAST, RIGGED POLLS CONTRIBUTED TO THE ALIENATION ON THE GROUND

Finally, it is time for the discourse to move "from being special" to "being equal". Most residents and leaders of the state would recognise that as an equal member of the Indian federal polity, they may enjoy greater freedom and rights than they did as a special state. After all, today, Tamil Nadu or West Bengal is able preserve its cultural identity, political space and economic well-being much better than J&K was able to do as a special state of the Union. ■

–Amitabh Mattoo is professor at JNU and a former advisor to the chief minister of Jammu & Kashmir

MAYAWATI

Heir (Half) Apparent

By Prashant Srivastava

SUMIT KUMAR



GENERATIONAL SHIFT BSP supremo Mayawati with nephew Akash Anand

Saffron is not the only political colour that's seeing a new coat of paint. The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), which continued its dismal run of form in the recent elections in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, is also gearing up for a generational shift. On December 10, at a Lucknow meeting convened to take stock of preparations for the 2024 Lok Sabha election, BSP supremo Mayawati named her 28-year-old nephew Akash Anand as her heir. The BSP's national coordinator now, Akash has been tasked with strengthening the party ahead of the summer polls, say those who attended the meeting. There's no change in his designation as such. But by projecting the young leader as the future BSP chief, the 67-year-old Mayawati is hoping to reinvigorate the cadre, who seem to have gone into limbo after getting battered at the hustings over and over again.

Against a context that paints the party's battle for relevance in such grim tones, the four-time former chief minister's announcement did not enthuse every section within Dalit politics equally—critics say this completes the conversion of an ideological party into another family estate. "It's not as if Kanshi Ram did not have family," went a caustic remark on X, referring to the Dalit stalwart/BSP founder who had chosen Mayawati as his protégé purely on leadership potential. If the heir too has that, it's yet to become fully apparent.